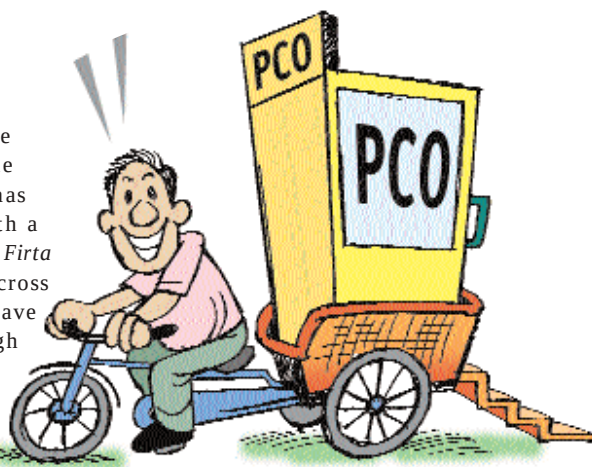


Pedalin' PCO

If people don't come to a mobile phone, take the mobile phone to the people! Jaipur-based Shyam Telecom has equipped a fleet of cycle-rickshaws with a mobile phone each. Called the *Chalta Firta PCO*, the rickshaw drivers pedal all across Jaipur, freely choosing their beat and have started making a decent income through their commission on this mobile pay-phone service. Shyam Telecom outfits the rickshaws with handsets for free, and derives income through the increased traffic on their network.

This is just the beginning; Shyam Telecom plans to broaden the mobile-to-mobile pay-phone service into mobile-a-cyber-cafe by adding Internet-ready laptops. And finally, get



ready for this one: they're running a pilot test to get camels on the Net, or rather, under it. Shyam Telecom currently has two camels roaming the deserts with wireless computers in tow, offering Internet connections to all!

An Ace(r) of a Ferrari

Anything fast has to be a Ferrari. Acer India has launched a limited edition of the Ferrari 3000 notebook. With a price tag of around Rs. 1.6 lakhs, the laptop was launched to celebrate Ferrari's Grand Prix world championship victory last year. It's

powered by an AMD Athlon XP-M 2500+, 512 MB of DDR SDRAM, a 60 GB hard drive, a DVD-Writer and a 15-inch screen backed by a 128 MB ATI Radeon graphics card. Communications is handled via an integrated 802.11g wireless LAN, Bluetooth, 10/100 Mbps Ethernet, and a 56 Kbps modem. It also has a multi-format four-in-one memory card reader, 4 USB 2.0 ports, an IEEE 1394 port and S-video port. Weighing 2.9 kg, it has a mileage of 3 hours.



Windows-powered cars

Microsoft has set its eyes on the car market, and it wants in-car electronics to run its Windows Automotive platform. With 50 million cars rolling out of assembly lines every year, Microsoft has sensed a huge market for its products. "We'd like to have one of our operating systems in every car. It's a lofty goal," says Dick Brass, vice president of Microsoft's Automotive Business Unit. The Windows Automotive platform

will have features such as hands-free communication, support for wireless standards such as GPRS, CDMA, WiFi, driver distraction control and entertainment services.

Microsoft is encouraging car manufacturers to use Windows CE to run navigation systems, entertainment systems, etc. Not only have premier car manufacturers—BMW, Honda and Volvo—shown interest, but 23 car models are currently using it. Modern cars are increasingly relying on computers to perform sophisticated functions such as GPS navigation and entertainment functions. Citroën's C5, for example, uses Windows-powered software to provide turn-by-turn navigation capabilities, hands-free cellular phone control, wireless synchronization of data with mobile devices, etc. Similarly, the BMW 7 series has a Windows-powered navigation application as a part of the new cabin design, iDrive.

Microsoft is not alone in

snapshot

At the end of **November 2003, India had 20.73 million GSM and 5.87 million CDMA subscribers**

Source: TRAI

heroes

Notebook sales
Laptop sales in India may finally rise. Notebook manufacturers are aggressively reducing the prices to grab market share, with almost all the laptop companies pegging the entry level price at around Rs 55,000.

Indian R&D
India is poised to become a global research and development hub. Google has set up a Research and Development lab at Bangalore. Intel already has one here to develop the next generation of mobile chipsets and server processors.

zeroes

Parts shortage

The demand of mobile phones world-wide has outstripped its supply. One reason is that there is a shortage of colour screens and cameras. Also, flash memory, used in removable storage devices such as USB sticks, is in short supply.

Windows 98

Officially, Windows 98 died on December 15, 2003, and will not be available through Microsoft's channels. Distribution of SQL server 7 and some Office 2000 related tools has also been halted.

The move is due to the agreement between Microsoft and Sun over the distribution of Java virtual machine.

this niche market, and faces competition from embedded software developers—Wind Systems, QNX software and, not to forget, embedded versions of Linux. Some of these companies' products are used in F1 cars. →